

Theoretical and Conceptual Framework of Mixed-Mode Delivery in Open and Distance Learning.

- Introduction:

Open and Distance Learning (ODL) constitutes a flexible and accessible instrumental system that has become critical for expanding educational opportunities worldwide. This paper explores the theoretical and conceptual framework of ODL, focusing specifically on its inherent nature as a mixed-mode delivery system – often referred to in contemporary terms as blended learning – which integrates various technological tools, asynchronous study materials, and essential face-to-face (F2F) interaction. Comprehending this framework is essential for navigating and succeeding in educational environments characterized by the separation of teacher and learner.

ODL is defined by the Commonwealth of Learning (COL, 2015) as an instructional system characterized by the **temporal and/or spatial separation of teacher and learner**, utilizing **multiple media** for instructional delivery. Crucially, this system incorporates **bi-directional communication** and includes **occasional in-person meetings for tutorials and peer interaction**. By synthesizing the historical evolution of distance education with the philosophical principles of open learning, ODL establishes a highly adaptable and technologically driven environment.

- Theoretical Framework: Defining Open and Distance Learning

The term “open and distance learning” integrates two distinct educational concepts: distance and open learning. While distance education has a well-established history, open learning is a comparatively recent development, emerging in the 1970s.

A. Distance Education: Historical Foundations

Distance Education is defined as an educational field focusing on teaching methods and technology to deliver instruction to students not physically present in a traditional classroom setting. The aim is to provide access to learning when the source of information and the learners are separated by time, distance, or both. The evolution of distance education methodology is typically categorized into three stages:

1. **Correspondence Stage:** This earliest form began in the mid-nineteenth century and involved the distribution of printed materials via mail, facilitating participant interaction correspondence. Pioneering efforts include Sir Isaac Pitman's shorthand courses starting in the 1840s.
2. **Sound and Video Signal Stage:** This phase commenced during World War 1 with the introduction of radio in 1916 and later television, with educational broadcast becoming a global tool for distance education by 1925.
3. **Computer Technology Stage:** Marking the third phase, the 1980s introduced computers and space satellites, enabling universities to offer programs to students located thousands of miles away. Technological advancements continue to impact educational delivery significantly in this current stage.

A. Open Learning Philosophy

Open learning is an innovative educational approach that emerged in the 1970s, emphasizing the expansion of learning opportunities both within and outside formal education system. Its philosophy focuses on learner autonomy, allowing students flexibility in choosing learning mediums, study locations and paces, support mechanisms, and entry and exit points.

The **fusion of open learning philosophy with distance education principles** gave rise to ODL, this growth has been significantly accelerated by Internet-based technologies, particularly World Wide Web. The pioneering Open University established in the United Kingdom in 1969 set a notable example for public distance learning institutions globally.

- **Conceptual Framework: Mixed-Mode Delivery Characteristics of ODL**

The mixed-mode or blended nature of ODL is evident in its core distinguishing characteristics, which move beyond conventional education models. These characteristics—Openness, Flexibility, Technological Integration, Mixed Media, and Interactivity—collectively define the delivery system.

A. Technologically Driven and Mixed Media Courseware

ODL is fundamentally technologically driven, a development accelerated by the advancement of information and communication technologies (ICTs). These technologies provide new opportunities for sharing information, resources, and experiences, as well as fostering network opportunities among peers, tutors, and instructors. The sources describe the fourth generation of Distance Education using terms like **e-Learning (electronic learning)**, **m-Learning (mobile learning)**, and **u-Learning (ubiquitous learning)**, characterizing it as an ‘empowered phase’.

The concept of a global classroom has been made a reality through ICTs, facilitated by educational software, satellite transmissions, and electronic networks. ODL utilizes a diverse array of media to deliver instruction, forming a comprehensive **mixed-media courseware** that includes print, radio, television broadcasts, audio, video, computer-based instruction, and telecommunications.

B. Flexibility and Openness

The blend of distance methods and open philosophy results in high levels of flexibility and accessibility:

1. **Flexibility:** This key feature is analyzed in terms of place, time, and pace.
 - a. *Flexibility in time* enables asynchronous learning, allowing learners who cannot attend live sessions to engage with the material later while still maintaining opportunities for peer and tutor interaction.
 - b. *Flexibility in place* eliminates the necessity of a physical location, allowing learners to access education from any location.

- c. *Flexibility in pace* caters to individual learning speeds, which is highly appealing for those with varying schedules and needs, such as employed professionals.
- 2. **Openness:** Openness is categorized into three areas: people, places, and ideas (Kanwar, 2015).
 - a. *Openness for people* focuses on increasing access by reducing or eliminating rigid entry requirements and providing opportunities for learners to choose subjects and study pace.
 - b. *Openness regarding places* eliminates physical institutional boundaries, enabling learning anytime and anywhere, often facilitated by digital technologies.
 - c. *Openness in ideas* refers to the free distribution and modification of educational content, leading to the development of **Open Educational Resources (OER)** and Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs), promoting unrestricted sharing.

C. Interactivity and Face-to-Face Components

The ODL framework specifically addresses the potential lack of direct contact by emphasizing interactivity and incorporating planned F2F engagement, forming the basis of its mixed-mode structure. The definition of ODL explicitly incorporates **occasional in-person meetings for tutorials and peer interaction**.

To bridge the gap created by the separation of student and teacher, ODL utilizes four types of interactivities:

1. **Learner-to-Content:** Engagement with various forms of course material, such as text, audio, or online communication.
2. **Learner-to-Instructor:** Receiving feedback and support from lecturers.
3. **Learner-to-Learner:** Fostering collaboration and critical thinking through peer exchanges.
4. **Learner-to-Technology (or learner-to-interface):** Engaging with the technological tools used to present course content.

Interactivity transforms the distance setting, enabling learners to collaborate with peers in virtual settings, share work, and interact in small or large groups, thereby avoiding the isolation characteristic of earlier distance education models.

- **Pedagogical Implications: Roles within the ODL Environment**

The instructional framework of ODL necessitates a transformation in the roles of both teachers and learners, emphasizing student-centered learning activities facilitated by their instructional technology.

A. The Role of the Teacher

In ODL, the teacher's role shifts significantly from being an absolute controller of information to that of a facilitator. The primary roles include:

1. **Creator and Manager of Learning Environment:** The teacher oversees discussion tracks, integrates various course components, contributes specialized knowledge, and fosters group cohesion. They act as a "tour guide," directing and redirecting learners' focus on essential concepts and ideas.
2. **Instructor:** The teacher delivers instruction, addresses student inquiries, and offers individualized support, helping students identify effective study methods and build self-confidence. They motivate students by outlining learning objectives and providing guidance on how to achieve them, such as furnishing academic calendars and rubrics.
3. **Facilitator:** In the collaborative learning paradigm, the teacher facilitates interactive processes among learners, often serving as a moderator in discussion forums, guiding interactions toward rigorous learning outcomes.

B. Learner Characteristics and Study Skills

Success in the mixed-mode ODL environment requires specific characteristics from the learner, moving away from passive reception towards active engagement. Key characteristics for ODL learners include:

- **Adaptation to Technology:** As the entire ODL process is automated (from admission to examination registration), learners must become computer literate and comfortable working in an online environment.

- **Discipline:** Self-discipline, self-monitoring, self-initiative, and self-management are essential, as the lack of a physical lecturer makes it easy to skip assignments. Creating a personal study timetable is crucial.
- **Active Participation:** Students must actively engage in all course requirements, including participating in discussion and chat forums. Active participation is the essential element in engaging in the learning process, fostering a collaborative community.
- **Effective Communication and Reflective Skills:** Learners must be effective communicators, engaging in discursive or dialogical skills (discussing issues, sharing and debating ideas, negotiating meaning). Reflective skills, defined as the ability to frequently and substantively assess one's learning process, are also crucial for identifying strengths and weaknesses.

The *learning environment* itself acts as the "third teacher," encompassing physical and virtual locations, cultural settings, teaching methods, and technology. It is a comprehensive software solution that supports online learning and integrates the functionalities of a Learning Management System (LMS).

- **Assessment and Evaluation in ODL**

Assessment is a crucial subsystem within the ODL framework, providing feedback, monitoring program effectiveness, and leading to certification. The assessment framework in ODL is inherently integrated into the learning process, supporting the mixed-mode delivery.

A. **Types of Assessment**

Assessment is generally divided into three types:

1. **Formative Assessment (Assessment for Learning):** This continuous process diagnoses learners' problems and difficulties during instructional processes, providing remediation and ongoing feedback.

2. **Summative Assessment (Assessment of Learning):** This is cumulative, confirming what students know and can do in relation to program outcomes, typically conducted at the end of a semester or session to determine overall achievement and leading to a degree.
3. **Assessment as Learning:** This emphasizes fostering students' metacognitive development, encouraging them to monitor and reflect on their learning to support and direct new learning.

B. Instructional-Based Assessment Modes

ODL employs assessment modes that reinforce the independent and technologically mediated nature of the system:

- **In-text/Self-Assessment:** Students apply criteria to their own work, discuss it with peers, and reflect on its post-completion. This method is highly effective when learning goals are clear, enabling students to accurately gauge their understanding and revisit materials to address deficiencies.
- **Tutor/Computer-Marked Assignment (TMAs/CMAs):** Assignments are essential for assessing student learning. TMAs are submitted to an instructor or facilitator for scoring and grading, with comments and feedback provided. CMAs are administered online and scored by the computer, with feedback provided through the online system. These assignments are mandatory and adhere to strict submission deadlines.

The goal of assessment activities is **evaluation**, which involves making a value judgment about the worth of a student's work or performance, facilitating decision-making, and guiding instructional management.

- Conclusion

The theoretical and conceptual framework of Open and Distance Learning effectively encompasses a sophisticated mixed-mode delivery system. By combining the historical emphasis of distance education on overcoming spatial separation with the philosophical mandate of open learning for accessibility, ODL provides a flexible, technology-driven environment.

The incorporation of **multiple media, bi-directional communication, and occasional in-person meetings** within its core definition ensures that ODL transcends purely online or purely F2F instruction. This integrated approach necessitates adaptive roles for teachers (shifting to facilitators) and students (requiring high discipline and technological adaptation). This model is critical in addressing modern educational needs, such as capacity constraints in traditional institutions and the persistent demand for lifelong learning.